

GOD'S PROVIDENCE

"Grandma, can you tell me a bedtime story please?" asked George.

"Oh all right," replied Grandma. "I'll tell you a story my mother once told me."

"Once upon a time, when I was a young snapper, swimming past a patch of slimy green seaweed, I saw a Gurnard. I think Gurnards are just beautiful, don't you?"

"What is a Gurnard?" asked George.

"Gurnards are fish with bright, orange scales and wings like a butterfly," replied Grandma. "Now where was I up to? Oh! I remember now. "

"Hello, how nice to meet you," Gurnard said. I am thrilled, no one usually stops to talk to me."

"Hi Gurnard," I said, "Would you like to come and rest awhile at my cave in the seaweed?"

I nearly yelled, I was so excited, oh how I hoped he would say yes.

"No, sorry Snapper, but I do have an important job for you. The Lord came to me early this morning and gave me a gold coin. He told me to give it to the first snapper I saw."

My heart sank; I didn't take any notice of what else he had said. All I heard was No, seriously, no.

"Hello?" said Gurnard, trying to get my attention, while passing me the shiny gold coin, "All you have to do, is keep it safe."

So, I popped it in my mouth and swam away. I grumbled to myself as I swam back to my house in the seaweed.

The next morning, I woke up with a spark of excitement, I finally realized that I had a shiny gold coin.

I carefully hid it where no fish could find it. I swam off to my favorite hunting spot. I got there when it was still dark, but since I have good eyesight, I could still see. I swam around, waiting for an easy catch, all the time thinking about the gold coin and why I had it. Just then a crab slunk passed.

I quickly gobbled it up and swam back to the seaweed.

When I got back, I went to get the coin. After several minutes of looking, I realized I had lost it!

Gurnard's words rung in my head, "Keep it safe." Gurnard would not be pleased. I had done the exact opposite of what he told me to do. I was swimming around in circles, feeling sorry for myself, when a kingfish swam towards me. Soon he was right behind me.

"Are you looking for this?" He said before he spat out the gold coin.

“Yes, thank you,” I said, excited to have it back.

“I have no use for it,” he said, before swimming off again.”

I was left by myself in the South Pacific Ocean, off the East Coast of New Zealand. For a few moments, the world seemed to stand still, as the last few days whirled around in my head. I started swimming as I slowly came out of my daydream. I realized I had no idea what I was supposed to be doing with this gold coin. I started swimming aimlessly, in circles, not knowing what to do next.

As I swam, something caught my eye; a piece of crab maybe? I started swimming toward it, ready for an easy catch. I opened my mouth wide and chomped down on some delicious crunchy crab.

Before I knew it, I was being pulled toward the surface of the water, I’d never been up there before. I was quite surprised, so I started wriggling around. I came to know that I was caught by something stuck in my mouth, so I tried to spit it out, but I couldn’t.

I was so busy struggling, I didn’t hear two men talking. I thought they were fishermen.

“I’ve got one, think it’s a kahawai.

“Do you want some help winding him in?”

“Nah, this should be an easy one.”

I heard this as I was being dragged toward the shore. My mind wandered from what was happening, and I started thinking about the coin again, was this the time it was to be used?

Suddenly I was pulled completely out of the water. I was hanging in the air for a few seconds, before being placed on a white, plastic board, which stunk like fish guts. Wait? Fish guts? I felt a sudden burst of energy, I started to fight, hoping that I could break free and fall back into the water. But I failed. I heard the man talking about retrieving a hook? I soon learned that a ‘hook’ was the thing that was stuck in my mouth.

One of the men opened my mouth and put their fingers in, they tasted absolutely foul. I lay there struggling to breathe. I heard one of the men giving a sudden shout of joy, he had found the coin. He pulled it out and waved it in front of his friend's face.

"Guess what I've found," he said, then started again. "It's a gold coin, a pure gold one I think, I could pay that tax that's been building up, oh, I'm so excited."

He was very energized by the thought of this and said an awful lot without taking a breath. I thought he was quite the chatterbox. He threw me back into the water and I heard no more of the ongoing chatter of that annoying man. I found myself in a channel, just off a bay, in the town of Pareora. I swam back to my cozy home embedded in the green, slimy, seaweed, happy that my adventures were over."

"So that, my dear George, is a story of how God provides for our needs. Now it really is time for you to get to bed, so put your pajamas on, brush your teeth and climb up to your bunk.

I'll come soon and tuck you in." Grandma felt happy to have a little quiet time to herself, she was tired, George was staying for the weekend, and she was ninety-three. Soon, when George came back to find Grandma, she was fast asleep in her rocker.

By Lucia Cullen

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